

Email Basics — Detailed Lecture Notes

JKSSB Computer Awareness

October 8, 2026

37.1 What email is

Electronic mail (email) is a message sent from one electronic mailbox to another over a network such as the Internet. Each user owns a mailbox identified by a unique email address. The sender composes a message, directs it with the recipient fields, and sends it; the message then waits in each recipient's mailbox until it is opened. Because delivery does not require both parties to be present at the same time, email is called a store-and-forward service.

Definition (Email address). *A unique identifier of a mailbox, written as a user name, then the @ symbol, then the domain name, for example `assistant@gmail.com`.*

Term	Meaning in this lesson
User name	The part of the address left of the @; the mailbox on the server.
Domain name	The part of the address right of the @; the mail server holding the mailbox.
To / Cc / Bcc	Recipient fields: primary recipient, visible copy, hidden copy.
Subject / body	The topic line and the main written content.
Attachment	A file sent along with the message.
Inbox / Sent / Drafts	Folders for received, sent, and unfinished mail.
Spam / Trash	Folders for filtered junk and for deleted messages.
Webmail / email client	Mail used in a browser vs mail used in an installed app.

The rest of this lesson uses these terms in one consistent sense. The **user name** is whatever stands left of the @ and the **domain name** is whatever stands right of it. **To** is the main recipient, **Cc** (Carbon Copy) is a visible additional recipient, and **Bcc** (Blind Carbon Copy) is a hidden additional recipient. **Subject** is the topic line, **body** is the message text, and an **attachment** is a separate file carried with the message.

37.2 The email address

Every email address contains exactly one @ symbol, read as “at”. The @ separates the user name on the left from the domain name on the right. In `assistant@gmail.com`, `assistant` is the user name and `gmail.com` is the domain name. The domain name identifies which mail server holds the mailbox; the user name identifies which mailbox on that server. This is the point tested when an item asks what the @ separates: the answer is the user name and the domain name (PYQ-35).

Definition (Domain name). *The part of an email address right of the @ that identifies the mail server or organisation holding the mailbox, such as `gmail.com`.*

Addresses are written without spaces, and the @ appears exactly once. Anything before it belongs to the user name; anything after it belongs to the domain. Options that say the @ separates the domain and the host, or two parts of the domain, are therefore wrong.

37.3 Recipient fields: To, Cc and Bcc

The three recipient fields decide who receives the message and who can see whom. **To** names the primary recipient, the person the message is mainly for. **Cc** (Carbon Copy) names additional recipients who receive a visible copy; every recipient can see the To and Cc lists. **Bcc** (Blind Carbon Copy) names additional recipients whose addresses are hidden from the other recipients.

Definition (Bcc). *A recipient field whose addresses are hidden from the other recipients of the same message; each Bcc recipient is concealed from the To, Cc, and fellow Bcc recipients.*

The word “blind” refers to this concealment. A Bcc recipient still receives the message normally. The other recipients simply cannot see that address. The sender, who composed the message, always knows the full list. To and Cc addresses, by contrast, are visible to everyone who receives the message. This is the distinction behind the common trap: Bcc hides recipients from each other, not from the sender, and it does not hide the To or Cc lists from anyone (TRAP-16).

Example 37.3.1. *The officer sends a notice To the assistant and Cc the clerk, with the head office on Bcc. The assistant and the clerk see each other’s addresses but cannot see the head office address. The head office receives the same notice. The sender (the officer) knows all three addresses.*

For the examination, read every Bcc option word by word. An option that says Bcc hides the sender is wrong; an option that says Bcc hides the To list from the recipients is wrong; the correct statement is that Bcc recipients are hidden from each other while To and Cc remain visible to all.

37.4 Subject, body and attachments

A message has two content parts and an optional file part. The **subject** is a single short line stating the topic, such as “Leave application for 12 October”. It is displayed in the message list before the message is opened, so a clear subject helps the recipient identify the message. The **body** is the main written content: the greeting, the message itself, and the closing.

An **attachment** is a file sent along with the message, usually shown with a paperclip icon. Common attachments are documents, spreadsheets, presentations, PDFs, and images. Attaching a file sends a copy to the recipient; the sender keeps the original. Two practical points matter for the examination. First, mail servers impose a size limit, so a very large file is rejected or must be shared as a link instead. Second, an attachment can carry a virus, so an unexpected attachment should not be opened blindly.

37.5 Folders: Inbox, Sent, Drafts, Spam, Trash

Received mail arrives in the **Inbox**. Every account has exactly one Inbox; it is the default view when the mailbox is opened. A copy of every message that is sent is kept in the **Sent** folder (sometimes labelled Sent Items or Sent Mail). A message that has been started but not yet sent can be saved in **Drafts**; it waits there until it is completed and sent.

Definition (Drafts). *The folder holding composed messages that have been saved but not yet sent.*

Unwanted or bulk mail is separated into the **Spam** folder (also called Junk). The mail service filters suspected junk out of the Inbox automatically; a wanted message found there should be moved back or marked “not spam”. Messages the user deletes go to the **Trash** folder (also called Deleted Items). They remain recoverable until the folder is emptied; emptying Trash or Spam permanently removes those messages.

The five folders are most easily confused in pairs. Inbox receives while Sent keeps sent copies; Drafts holds work not yet sent while Sent holds work already sent; Spam holds filtered junk while Trash holds what the user deleted. No other folder does another’s job: drafts never send themselves, sent copies never return to drafts, and spam is not the delete bin.

37.6 Reply, Reply All and Forward

Three actions dispose of a received message. **Reply** composes an answer addressed only to the sender. **Reply All** composes an answer addressed to the sender plus all the To and Cc recipients of the original message. **Forward** sends the received message onward to new recipients chosen by the forwarder, usually with a short added note on top.

Definition (Reply All). *A response addressed to the sender and to every visible (To and Cc) recipient of the original message; Bcc recipients of the original are never re-added.*

Two consequences follow. First, Reply All can only reach the addresses visible on the original message, so hidden Bcc addresses are never included. Second, a forwarded message carries the original content (and often its attachments) inside the new message; the forwarder becomes the new sender. For the examination, match the verb to the action: “answers only the sender” is Reply; “answers everyone visible” is Reply All; “sends it onward to new recipients” is Forward.

37.7 Webmail versus an email client

Email can be used in two ways. **Webmail** means using mail through a web browser, with the mailbox kept on the provider’s server; Gmail, Yahoo Mail, and Outlook.com are webmail services. An **email client** is an installed application used for mail, such as Microsoft Outlook or Mozilla Thunderbird; it can keep or download copies on the local machine.

Closely tied to the client are the incoming-mail protocols. **POP3** (Post Office Protocol version 3) downloads mail to the local machine, usually removing it from the server. **IMAP** (Internet Message Access Protocol) keeps mail synced on the server, so a phone, an office computer, and a laptop all show the same folders. Outgoing mail in both arrangements is normally sent with **SMTP** (Simple Mail Transfer Protocol). The one-line contrast to remember is: POP3 downloads, IMAP syncs, SMTP sends.

Example 37.7.1. *The assistant reads office mail in two places: through Gmail in the browser (webmail) and through the Outlook app on the office computer (email client) configured with IMAP, so a message read on one device shows as read on the other. Had the client used POP3, the downloaded message would sit on that one computer instead of staying synced on the server.*

37.8 Exam retrieval and common confusions

Six distinctions prevent most errors on this topic.

1. The @ separates the **user name** (left) from the **domain name** (right). It does not separate domain and host (PYQ-35, TRAP-28).

2. **Bcc** hides recipients from **each other**; the sender always knows, and To/Cc stay visible to all (TRAP-16).
3. **Cc** is Carbon Copy (visible); **Bcc** is Blind Carbon Copy (hidden). Do not swap “blind” and “visible”.
4. **Reply** answers the sender; **Reply All** answers all visible recipients; **Forward** sends the message onward.
5. **Drafts** holds unsent work, **Sent** holds sent copies, **Inbox** holds received mail, **Spam** holds filtered junk, and **Trash** holds deleted mail.
6. **Webmail** runs in a browser; an **email client** is installed software. **POP3** downloads mail to the machine while **IMAP** keeps it synced on the server.

Exercises

1. In the address `assistant@gmail.com`, identify the user name and the domain name. What does the @ separate?
2. Distinguish To, Cc, and Bcc by stating who can see whom.
3. Distinguish the subject, the body, and an attachment.
4. State which folder holds each of the following: an unfinished message, a copy of a sent message, a newly arrived message, filtered junk, a deleted message.
5. Distinguish Reply, Reply All, and Forward.
6. Distinguish webmail from an email client, and POP3 from IMAP.

Solutions

1. The user name is `assistant` and the domain name is `gmail.com`. The @ separates the user name (left) from the domain name (right).
2. To is the primary recipient and Cc is a visible copy; both lists are seen by all recipients. Bcc is a hidden copy: each Bcc address is concealed from the other recipients, while the sender knows the full list.
3. The subject is the short topic line shown in the message list; the body is the main written content; an attachment is a separate file carried with the message (shown with a paperclip icon).
4. Unfinished: Drafts. Sent copy: Sent. Newly arrived: Inbox. Filtered junk: Spam (junk). Deleted: Trash (deleted items), recoverable until emptied.
5. Reply answers only the sender; Reply All answers the sender plus all visible To and Cc recipients (never Bcc); Forward sends the received message onward to new recipients.
6. Webmail is mail used through a browser with the mailbox on the server (Gmail, Yahoo Mail, Outlook.com); an email client is installed software (Outlook, Thunderbird). POP3 downloads mail to the local machine, usually removing it from the server; IMAP keeps mail synced on the server so all devices show the same folders.